ODD.

ONE-DOC DRIVEN DEVELOPMENT

One request. One file. No approval, no apply.

A protocol that lets anyone, including people outside IT, safely ask AI to build software.

proposal.odd.md

1. Ask	Requester
2. Propose	AI
3. Approve	Owner + IT Guardian
4. Apply	AI
5. Check	Requester

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v1.0

AI can already build software. The hard part is knowing what to ask for and who says it's OK.

On engineering teams, **Spec-Driven Development (SDD)** solves this with discipline: a PRD becomes a Proposal, the Scrum Master and Tech Lead sign off, and only then does the AI or the developer apply the change. It works, but it assumes several documents and technical people at every step.

Outside IT (HR, finance, operations, support) people also have problems a small tool would solve. Without a lightweight process they're left with two bad options: ask for nothing, or ask the AI directly, with no scope, no approval and no record.

1
file per request

5
simple questions

2
approvals before apply

ODD keeps the discipline of SDD and fits all of it into a single file, written in everyday language.

02 · MANIFESTO

Six rules, no exceptions

01

One request, one file.

Everything that matters about the change lives in one `.odd.md`.

02

People write like people.

The Ask is in everyday language. The AI translates it into technical terms.

03

AI writes, humans decide.

The AI proposes and executes. People approve. Always.

04

No approval, no apply.

Approval is recorded in the file, never only in a chat.

05

The file is the memory.

Who asked, why, who approved and what was done, in one place.

06

Small by default.

Grew too big? Split it into more files or graduate to SDD.

03 · THE FLOW

Five phases, one file

1

Ask Requester

Answers 5 questions: what, why, who uses it, how you'll know it worked, what must not happen.

2

Propose AI

Writes scope, acceptance criteria, risks and the execution plan, in plain language.

3

Approve Owner + IT Guardian

The owner approves the **what**. The IT Guardian approves the **risk**: data, access, cost.

4

Apply AI

Checks both approvals, builds following the plan and logs what it did.

5

Check Requester

Tests every acceptance criterion and closes the request.

↺ Changes requested at approval? The file goes back to the Ask and the AI writes a new Proposal.

The header tells the story

`draft` → `in-review` → `approved` → `applied` → `checked`

Every section has an owner

1 Ask
Requester
Five questions in everyday language.

2 Proposal
AI
Summary, scope (does / does not), acceptance criteria, how it works, risks, plan and open questions.

3 Approval
Owner + IT Guardian
Each one's decision, name, date and comment.

4 Apply log
AI
What was done, where it lives, how to test, deviations.

5 Check
Requester
Criteria tested and final result.

ODD-0001-vacation-tracker.odd.md

```
status: approved
risk: medium

## 1. Ask
I want the team to log vacations
and to see who's out each week.

## 2. Proposal
- [ ] Given Ana is off Jan 08-15,
  when Carla books Jan 10-20,
  then a warning is shown.

## 3. Approval
| Owner       | approved | Nov 04 |
| IT Guardian | approved | Nov 04 |
```

AI The AI only edits sections 2 and 4. Sections 1, 3 and 5 belong to people.

Four roles, one golden rule

Requester

The person with the problem. Writes the Ask and checks the result.

AI

Writes the Proposal and runs the Apply. **Never approves.**

Business owner

Decides whether it's worth doing and whether the scope is right.

IT Guardian

Someone from tech who reviews **risk**, not code: data, access, cost, integrations.

The Apply gate

- ✓ `status: approved` in the header
- ✓ Owner **and** IT Guardian approved, with name and date
- ✓ No open questions in section 2.7

If any check fails, the AI stops and explains what's missing. If mid-apply the work needs to leave the scope, the change goes back for approval.

Risk levels

Low

Personal or team use, no personal data.

Medium

Small amounts of personal data, or corporate sign-in.

High

Sensitive data, production or several systems: graduate to SDD.

06 · SDD VS ODD

ODD doesn't replace SDD. It's the on-ramp.

	SDD (Spec-Driven)	ODD (One-Doc)
For	Development teams	Anyone
Artifacts	PRD, Proposal, specs, design, tasks	1 file
Who writes	PO, SM, developer	Requester + AI
Approval	SM/PO + Tech Lead	Owner + IT Guardian
Language	Technical	Everyday
Sweet spot	Features and systems	Small tools

When to graduate to SDD

- High risk
- More than one system involved
- Sensitive data at scale
- Proposal longer than ~2 pages

07 · GET STARTED

From zero to first apply in 5 minutes

1. Copy the template from the `templates/` folder into your repository.
2. Fill in only section 1, the **Ask**.
3. Run `/odd-propose` in Claude Code, or paste the Propose prompt into any AI.
4. Send the file to the owner and the IT Guardian to fill in the **Approval**.
5. Approved? Run `/odd-apply`. The AI checks the gate and builds.
6. Test the acceptance criteria and close it in section 5.

What's in the repository

`AGENTS.md`	rules for any AI agent
`.claude/commands/`	/odd-propose and /odd-apply
`templates/`	the blank ODD file
`prompts/`	Propose and Apply, for any AI
`examples/`	a complete, filled-in case

Use it, critique it, contribute: open an issue or a PR on GitHub.

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